

A LOCALITY'S LIFELINE
S. Vishwanath sitting next to a half-century-old well at Sonnapannahalli in Bengaluru

JITHENDRA M

would get the equivalent of 3,000 million litres per day. That's twice the volume of water being pumped into the city from the Cauvery (1,450 MLD) across a distance of 120 km. Currently, however, the peripheral parts of the city are still awaiting the supply of piped Cauvery water, and thus remain dependent on borewells for sustenance. It has led to a paradoxical situation—the overexploitation of groundwater means that even the borewells are running dry, while the rainwater is running off the city's concrete surfaces without percolating down to the aquifers, leading to flooding of localities during a downpour. "If we can tap half of the rainwater and push it into the ground, that's the equivalent of another Cauvery flowing right below us," says Vishwanath. That's where the recharge wells—which push the rainwater from the rooftops and roads into the ground—and the Mannu Vaddars who dig them come into play.

By promoting well-digging through the Million Wells campaign, Vishwanath and his team bring citizens in contact with the community. There are about 750 well-diggers in Bengaluru for whom this is the main source of livelihood.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Open wells are rural India's swimming pools. It gives me great joy to see children swim in their cool waters during summer holidays when mercury soars to 45 degrees Celsius outside"

S. VISHWANATH, Founder, Million Wells campaign

They also happen to be a repository of information about wells in the city. Shankarappa, 44, from the Bengaluru suburb of Sarjapura, recalls how, as a toddler, he would accompany his father as he went from locality to locality, digging new wells or cleaning old ones. "Even 15 years ago, a batch of six men would dig two to three wells a month," says Shankarappa. But work has dwindled in the years since, he says. The Million Wells campaign, therefore, is an attempt to reconnect citizens with an urban necessity and also a cultural history.

"People have their personal, unique stories related to wells," says Vishwanath. "The effort here is to bring wells back into open consciousness, and make sure that they are functional and clean, and that the heritage is protected." Currently, there are an estimated 250,000 wells across the city. "We want to highlight the happy stories around wells to get more and more people to participate," says Shubha Ramachandran, the water team lead at Biome Environmental Trust, which Vishwanath set up in 2009. While Biome has been promoting wells for long, the Million Wells for Bengaluru campaign was formalised in July 2015. The campaign has also served as a model for the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation piloted in 10 cities, Bengaluru being one of them. ■